

Courtship

Mating in most mammals and birds takes place only at certain times of the year. Courtship describes the behaviour used by male animals to attract a female and mate with her. It informs a potential mate that the intention is breeding and not aggression. During courtship, males usually compete with each other to attract females, advertise that they are ready to mate, and encourage females to be sexually responsive. Females select males by the quality of their courtship display.

Domestic cats

A female cat comes on heat, or is sexually responsive, about twice a year. She produces scents and calls loudly to attract males. Several males may compete for her by fighting. The successful male encourages the female by touching her and calling softly.



Bird of paradise

Most birds have fixed courtship displays that ensure they attract a mate of the same species. Male birds often have brighter plumage than females, and this is especially true of the emperor bird of paradise. Males compete for females by quivering their long feathers and calling loudly.

Territorial behaviour

Many animals defend their territory to maintain access to food, water, shelter, and somewhere to reproduce. Territories can be large or small and held by one animal or by a group. Birdsong or the marking of territorial boundaries may deter rivals from entering a territory and avoid conflict and possible fatal injuries.

Cats

Most cats are solitary and maintain a territory on their own. Cheetahs patrol their territory and mark its boundaries by spraying urine on trees and other landmarks. The scent warns neighbouring cheetahs not to intrude.



Kittiwakes

Like many gull species, kittiwakes nest in colonies on narrow cliff ledges. Each pair of birds defends a small territory on the ledge, just large enough for the female to lay eggs and raise their young.

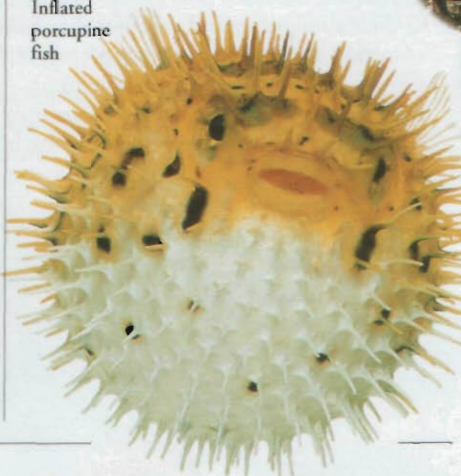


Aggression

Animals show aggression to other members of their species when competing for food, water, shelter, or mates. Some animals use horns, some use teeth or claws, and others kick.

In many cases, animals signal their aggressive intent. This may defuse the situation and prevent injury.

Inflated porcupine fish



Fighting bighorn sheep

Aggression within a species

These bighorn sheep use their horns to clash head-on in competition for mates. The winner of the fight gains higher social ranking and more females. Aggression like this is highly ritualized, and neither male is likely to be injured.

Aggression between species

Animals may be aggressive towards members of other species that are threatening or attacking them. Some animals use a threat display, often making themselves bigger to deter enemies. This porcupine fish inflates its body like a balloon and erects its spines.

Social behaviour

Social animals live in groups. Individuals co-operate to find food, defend themselves, and look after the young. Social groups range from shoals of fish, which are purely defensive, to societies of honeybees, where social organization affects all aspects of an individual's life.



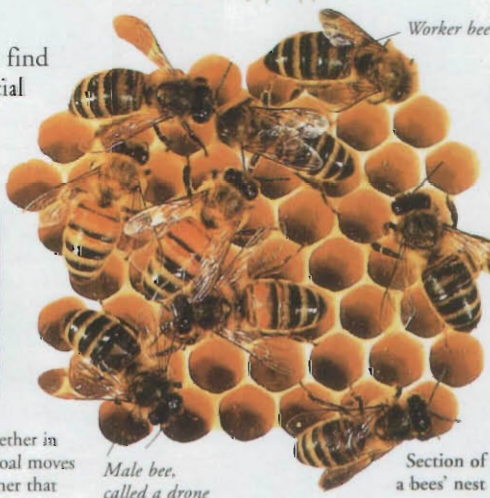
Helping others

African wild dogs are social animals and often help each other. Male dogs will look after pups that are not their own, but were fathered by a brother or close relative. In this way they help pups to survive.



Living in large numbers

Many fish species swim close together in large numbers called shoals. A shoal moves and turns in a co-ordinated manner that mimics a single large living organism. Predators find it difficult to focus on one individual within the shoal.



Konrad Lorenz

Austrian zoologist Konrad Lorenz (1903-89) pioneered the study of animal behaviour. As part of his work on individual and group behaviour, Lorenz discovered imprinting. Lorenz shared a Nobel Prize in 1973 for his work.



Social insects

Within a colony of social insects, such as bees, there are groups that carry out certain tasks. In a bee colony a single queen lays eggs, while sterile female workers look after the young, collect food, and defend the colony. Male bees fertilize the queen.

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